

Alpine chipmunk

Tamias alpinus

Chipmunks are small, squirrel-like creatures of open spaces. Alpine chipmunks are found only in California's Sierra Nevada mountains, surviving above 8,000 ft (2,500 m) on broken cliffs and scree with abundant cavities and plentiful seeds of grasses, sedges, and stunted pines. They hibernate from mid-October to June to escape the worst of winter. They store little fat, but cache surplus food in summer and wake often to feed during winter, in between several days of torpor. Alpine chipmunks have no need to find and drink water as they get sufficient moisture from their food.



- ↔ 6–7 in (15–18 cm)
- ⚖ 1–2 oz (28–57 g)
- ⊗ Locally common
- 🌿 Seeds, fruit
- 🏠 🌲 🏔 SW. US

◀ ROCKY PERCH

Deep, narrow crevices retain heat in high, exposed places, helping this small mammal to survive.

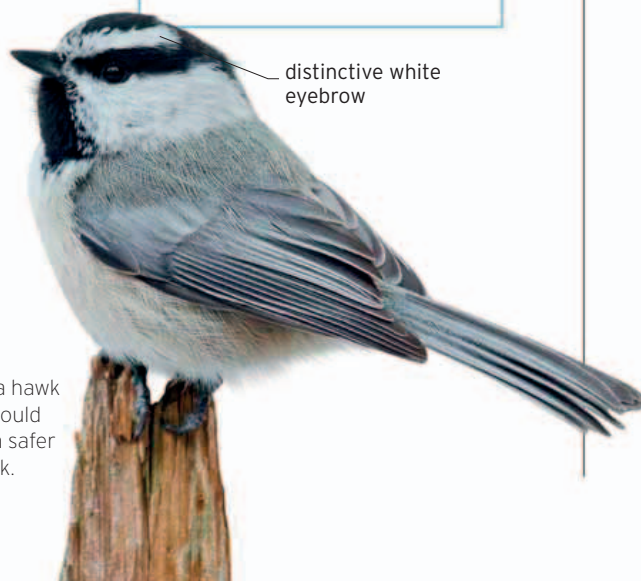
Mountain chickadee

Poecile gambeli

Tits, or titmice, are common worldwide. Several North American species are known as chickadees due to their “chick-a-dee” call. Active, acrobatic, social feeders, mountain chickadees join mixed flocks roaming high coniferous woods in search of food in fall and winter. A dispersed flock is more likely to find good feeding places than a lone bird, and many pairs of eyes are better at spotting danger.

▷ SOLE TARGET

Should a predator such as a hawk appear, a lone chickadee would be its only target. It is much safer to be one of many in a flock.



- ↔ 6 in (15 cm)
- ⚖ $5/16$ – $3/8$ oz (10–18 g)
- ⊗ Common
- 🌿 Seeds, small insects, spiders
- 🏠 🌲 🏔 N., W., and S. North America

distinctive white eyebrow



Turkey vulture

Cathartes aura

The turkey vulture is one of seven New World vultures, all of which scavenge dead animals and ride up-currents of warm air over vast areas. They soar on wings raised in a “V” shape for extra stability, their body weight slung low. Their slotted wingtips reduce turbulence—a feature copied by early aircraft designers.

Mutual dependence

While all vultures have excellent sight, few have a keen sense of smell. In forests, other vultures follow turkey vultures to locate carcasses hidden under trees because they can locate food by smell. When large carcasses are found, turkey vultures stand aside as bigger species with stronger beaks open up tough hides. All vultures prefer newly dead animals and avoid putrefying meat.

Turkey vultures that breed in the north migrate to the tropics in winter, but many stay in the southern US all year round. They breed in early spring in the south and in July or August farther north, laying their eggs on a cliff ledge, or sometimes in a hollow tree or dense thicket. Two eggs are incubated for up to 40 days, and the chicks are fed in the nest for about 10 weeks.

Turkey vultures can **smell** newly dead animals

